BRIEFING

European Parliament

# 'This is Europe' debates in the European Parliament, 2022-2024

## An analysis of the speeches by EU Heads of State or Government

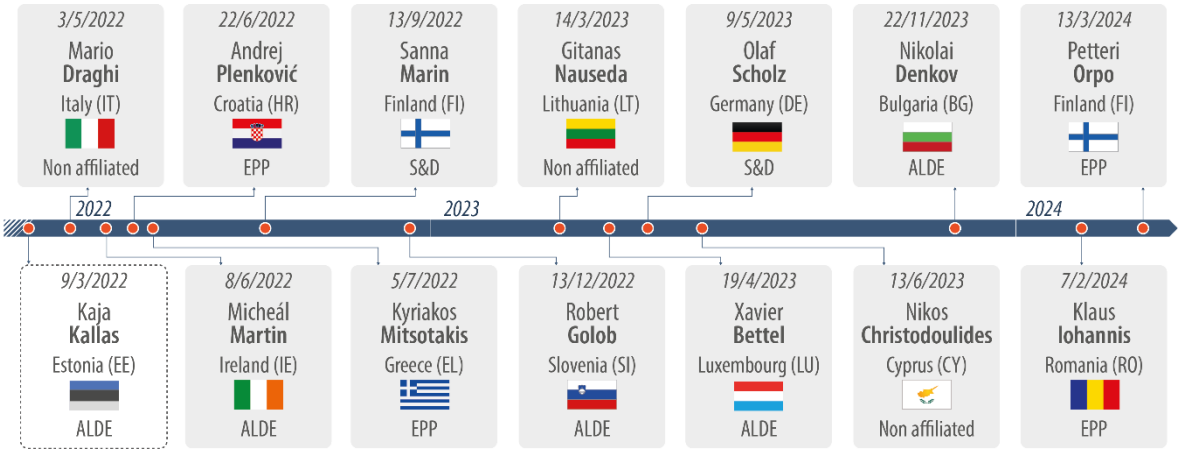
In a series of 'This is Europe' debates, from 2022 to 2024, many EU Heads of State or Government have addressed the European Parliament, to present their vision for Europe and its future. Touching on past and present crises, they have outlined the policy areas that they believe the EU should concentrate on in the future. While every speaker has had their own focus, there have been six recurring themes: (i) the value of EU membership; (ii) the importance of defending EU values; (iii) the main challenges facing the EU; (iv) the need to deliver for EU citizens; (v) the next steps in EU integration; and (vi) the importance of EU unity. While offering a unique analysis of all of these contributions, this briefing outlines the main messages, the key topics, and similarities and differences between the various speakers. It also examines the focus of participants based on party political affiliation and provides a comparison with the previous debates on the future of Europe with EU Heads of State or Government, in 2018-2019.

## Introduction

Roberta Metsola launched the 'This is Europe' initiative soon after her election as President of the European Parliament (EP) in January 2022. She invited Heads of State or Government who were also members of the European Council[1] to come to Parliament and discuss their visions for the future of the European Union.

Since 28 April 2022, when Parliament's Conference of Presidents endorsed the initiative, 13 EU leaders have addressed the Parliament in plenary,[2] presenting their views and subsequently engaging in a debate with the Members of the European Parliament.

Figure 1 – Participants in 'This is Europe' debates in the European Parliament (2022-2024)




Source: EPRS.

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Author: Ralf Drachenberg with Paweł Bącal Graphics by Gyorgyi Macsai
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The debates took place in a very specific context and time. They started shortly after Russia launched its unprovoked attack on Ukraine, changing the geopolitical situation in Europe overnight. During the same period, the Conference on the Future of Europe (CoFoE), a bottom-up exercise that allowed EU citizens to express their opinions on the EU's future policies and functioning, finalised its deliberations. On 30 April 2022, the CoFoE plenary adopted 49 proposals (see EPRS overview), including more than 300 measures by means of which these proposals could be achieved.

The 'This is Europe' debates were also an innovative way to frame an interaction between the members of two key EU institutions, the European Council and the European Parliament. Whereas Members of Parliament have regular plenary debates with the President of the European Council, Charles Michel, and the President of the Commission, Ursula von der Leyen, after each regular European Council meeting (see EPRS Interaction between the European Parliament and the European Council), the 'This is Europe' debates offered an important and less frequent opportunity for direct interaction between the Members of the European Parliament and the other Members of the European Council. They were also a welcome opportunity for EU leaders to explore broader reflections on the EU – beyond the short and often topical press statements at European Council meetings (see EPRS Unity and diversity in European Council media interactions).

The focus of the 'This is Europe' debates evolved over time: as the EU's five-year institutional cycle neared its end, they offered an opportunity to reflect on the future of the EU, and to raise awareness of citizens and politicians alike of both the European elections and the policy priorities for the next institutional cycle (2024-2029).

Figure 2 – EU leaders who took part in the 2022-2024 series of 'This is Europe' debates

# Common elements

As well as sharing their thoughts on the future of Europe, the EU leaders who addressed the European Parliament in the 'This is Europe' debates used the opportunity to report on important EU achievements in recent years, outline their own national activities and successes, make specific proposals for new initiatives and/or suggest adjustments to existing EU policies. Although the specific focus of each speaker differed, certain elements were addressed by almost all of them.

## Impact of EU membership

Many EU leaders reported on their Member State's experience of EU membership. This was particularly but not exclusively the case for leaders from countries having joined in or after 2004, who stressed the 'transformative power' of EU membership. All speakers underlined the benefits of EU membership for their country and the resulting sustained progress their countries had experienced. Several speakers also stated that EU membership was not a threat to, but an enabler and protector of their national sovereignty. They stressed that EU membership had protected their countries from the more severe effects of various past crises. Speakers also highlighted how their Member State's EU membership had benefited the EU, giving concrete examples.

## Celebrating and defending EU values

All the Heads of State or Government referred to EU values in their speeches. Many stressed that the EU was a 'community of values', with Olaf Scholz and Nikolai Denkov spelling out EU values as: 'solidarity, freedom, democracy, equality before the law, the rule of law, respect for human dignity and the fundamental rights of all citizens'. All the speakers agreed that EU values were something to be proud of and worth defending, from external as well as internal treats. Robert Golob reported

how EU values, notably the freedom of speech and the media, had been undermined in his own Member State. Micheál Martin reminded everyone that 'if we want the values of a free, democratic and prosperous Europe to survive and succeed, we have to speak up for these values – and we have to do so even when it's uncomfortable'.

## Main challenges

EU leaders outlined the main challenges that the EU has been facing in recent years and their views on current and up-coming challenges. Some speakers stayed at a more abstract level ('the historic challenges the EU is facing'), while most listed specific challenges, at various – Member State, EU and global – levels. Specific EU internal challenges were mentioned, notably the need to strengthen the EU's competitiveness, complete banking union, invest in the digital transition and increase solidarity. The foremost global challenge is seen as Russia's assault on the rules-based international order, displayed most strikingly in its war in Ukraine. Linked to these issues, the EU leaders highlighted energy dependency, inflation and disinformation. Other geopolitical challenges raised include the worsening situations in the Middle East, Africa and the Far East. Many EU leaders stressed that the climate crisis was a crucial challenge for the EU to tackle.

## Delivering for EU citizens

Unsurprisingly, EU citizens were a central concern for all speakers, but with differing areas of consideration. Many EU leaders mentioned that EU policies should benefit citizens and contribute to EU prosperity; work at EU level should thus be about finding solutions to citizens' problems. For Martin, the guiding principle should be 'to prepare the Union to continue to meet the needs of its citizens into the future'. Some stressed that the trust of citizens needed to be regained, and Kyriakos Mitsotakis, identified an 'unfortunate distance to citizens'. Speakers also underlined the need to bring EU citizens closer to the EU institutions, making them aware of what the EU is doing to improve their daily lives. Therefore, Klaus Iohannis and Nikos Christoudolides proposed making efforts to improve communication with EU citizens. Some were also demanding of citizens: Denkov said that the citizens' perception of the EU as being mainly a 'source of generous funds, benefits and a place for better paid work' needs to be changed, and adapted the John F. Kennedy quote to tell them: 'do not ask what the EU can do for your country, ask what your country can do for the EU'. Xavier Bettel and Sanna Marin focused on the input made by EU citizens and on how their ideas needed to feed bottom-up into the decision-making process.

## Next steps in EU integration

More EU integration was seen by many EU leaders as an essential means of addressing the challenges facing the EU. Not all went as far as Mario Draghi and Christodoulides, promoting a 'targeted, step-by-step process, aimed at building an EU with purely federal characteristics', but all advocated strengthening the EU and its institutions and boosting cooperation between its Member States.

## EU unity

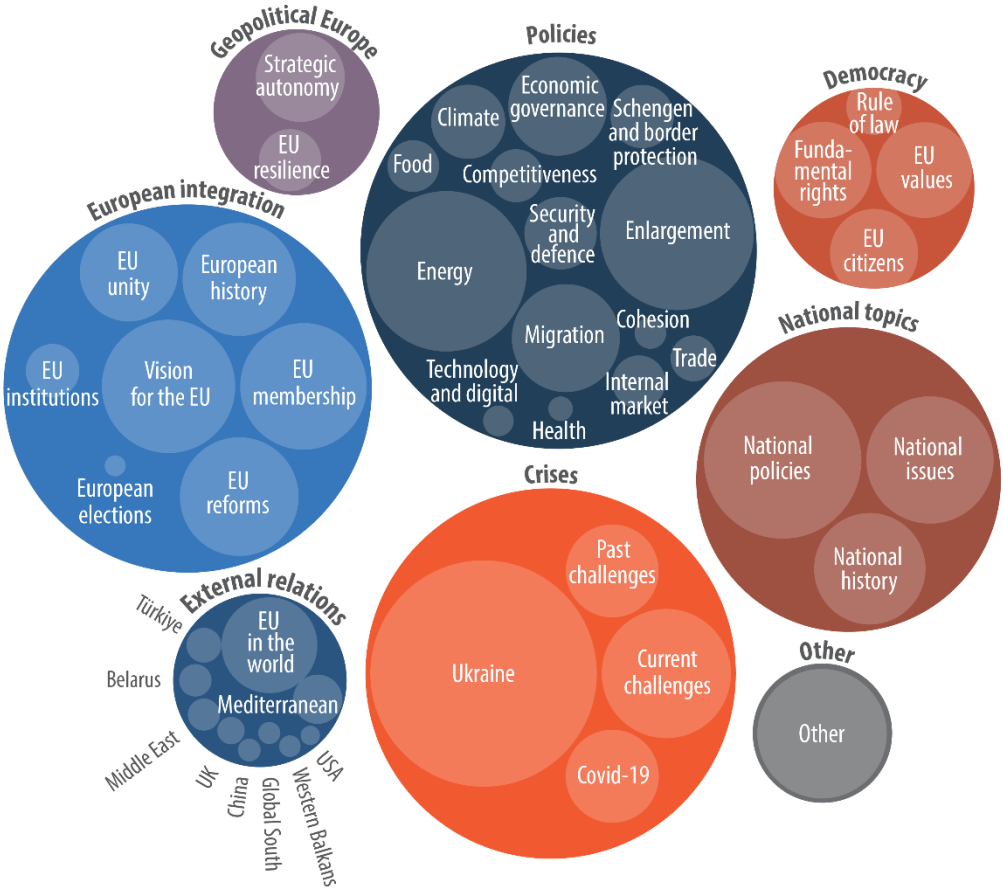
Alongside increased integration, the EU leaders considered EU unity to be a crucial element in facing and overcoming past, current and future challenges. Many speakers stressed that unity was the EU's greatest strength. This EU unity does not mean that Member States do not have diverging views and/or interests. Martin explained that it was the EU's capacity to work through the differences arising between Member States that made it something to be proud of.

# Main topics and priorities

In total, the analysis looked at 43 topics addressed by the various speakers. These 43 topics can be classified into seven macro-categories: (i) policies; (ii) crises (including for instance the war in Ukraine and COVID-19); (iii) European integration; (iv) national topics (i.e. specific to one Member State, such

as peace in Ireland, or the reunification of Cyprus); (v) democracy; (vi) external relations (i.e. relations with individual countries rather than a holistic approach); and (vii) geopolitical Europe (for instance strategic autonomy and EU resilience).

Figure 3 – Macro-categories of all topics

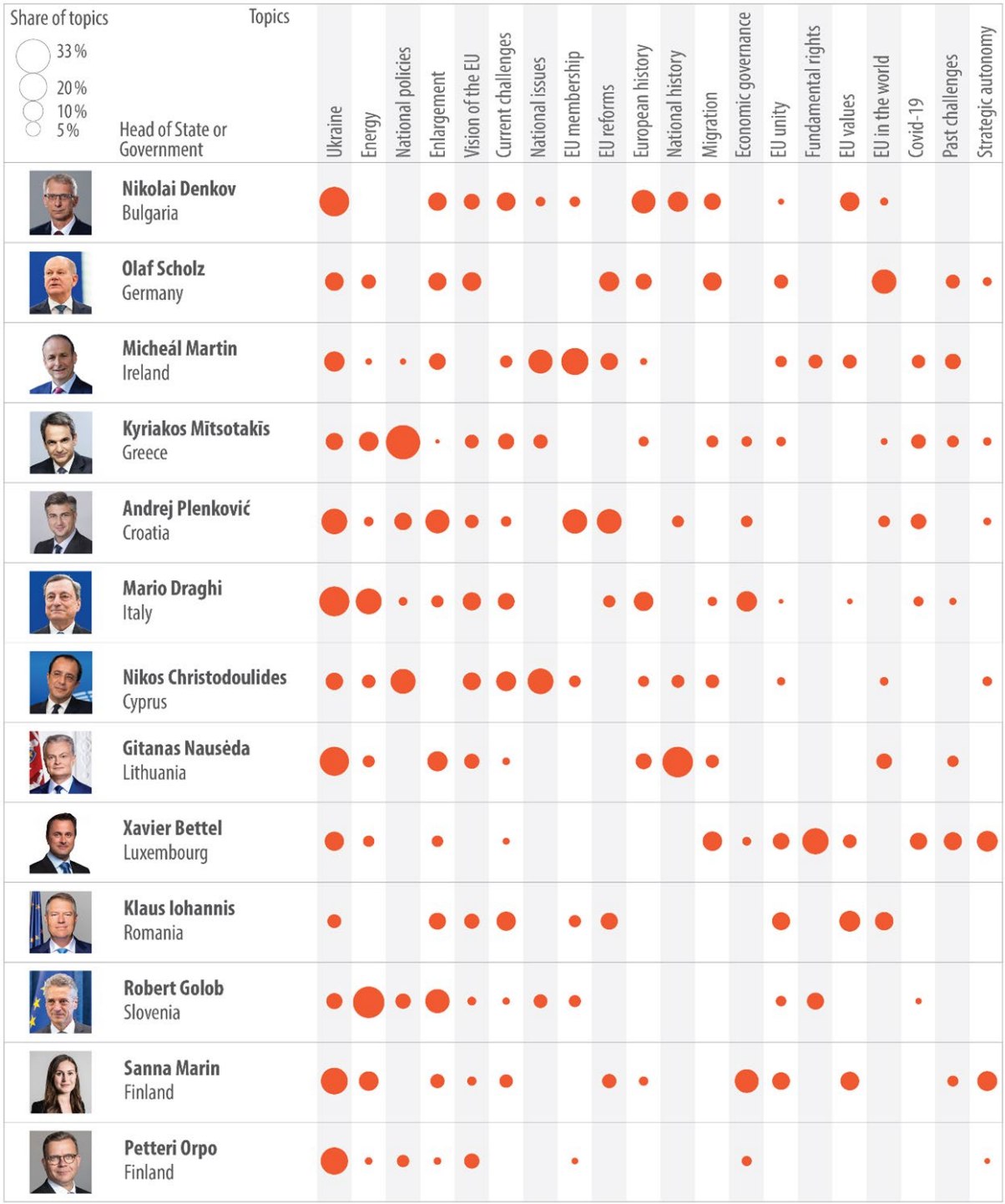



Source: EPRS.

## Main topics

When analysing the main topics, a distinction must be drawn between the number of speakers having addressed a topic and the attention (in number of words) given by each speaker to a given topic. The analysis examines both these elements and outlines how they correspond. Not all speakers covered the same range of topics. While on average, each speaker covered 17 topics, Martin and Mitsotakis addressed 20 topics, Gitanas Nauseda 14. The leaders who gave the longest speeches were: Christodoulides, Andrej Plenković and Draghi, whereas Iohannis, Marin and Petteri Orpo gave the shortest.

Figure 4 – Attention given by each speaker to the 20 most addressed topics.[3]




Source: EPRS.

## Number of speakers mentioning a topic and total attention

Figure 4 shows that the topics most often mentioned by EU leaders were Ukraine, enlargement, their vision for the EU, current challenges, and energy. The topics addressed by comparatively fewer speakers were past challenges, national policies, migration, and the EU in the world.

Figure 5 shows the attention devoted to each topic. On Ukraine, there is a clear correlation between how many speakers spoke on the topic and how much they had to say on it. Ukraine was mentioned by the highest number of speakers – all – and it was also the topic to which they devoted most time.

For topics such as 'current challenges', 'energy' and 'enlargement' both types of data mostly correspond to each other. Outliers were 'EU unity' and 'vision of Europe'. While 10 speakers addressed the former and 11 the latter, most dealt with them rather briefly. Conversely, while only seven speakers talked about 'national policies', it was on average the topic with the third highest share of attention. This result is mainly linked to the speeches by Mitsotakis and Christodoulides, which account for over 75 % of this category.

Figure 5 – Number of speakers addressing a given topic

Source: EPRS.

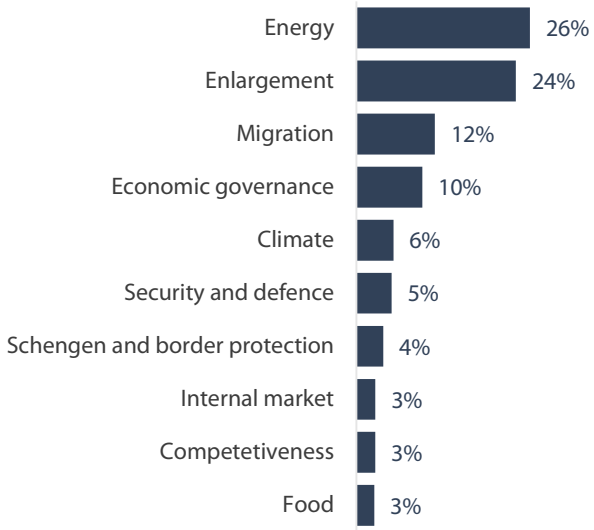
Figure 6 – Amount of attention given to different topics

Source: EPRS.

## Attention by EU policy

Figure 7 shows that energy and enlargement combined make up 50 % of all the attention given by EU leaders to policy topics.[4] Migration and economic governance were also invoked relatively often. Noteworthy is the paucity of references to social policy. While a few mentioned it, they talked about it only in the context of national – and not EU – policy. Other topics that were mentioned by only a few speakers were trade policy (Scholz and Orpo), health policy (Martin) and cohesion policy (Orpo).

Figure 7 – Attention by EU policy




Source: EPRS.

# Selected topics

## Ukraine

All the EU leaders referred to Ukraine in their speeches. This was also the topic to which the speakers devoted the most time. The Heads of State or Government mentioned this issue in the context of the Russian war of aggression. First, each leader underlined that the EU needed to support Ukraine. That was the case both for the speeches delivered shortly after Russia's full-scale invasion, and those delivered at a later stage. In this last group, warnings are issued, such as that of Iohannis, that support for Ukraine 'cannot be subject to any fatigue'. Second, some speakers, such as Scholz and Martin, advocated the provision of support to Ukraine even after the end of the war. Third, the majority of leaders also referred to the different dimensions of the EU's response to Russia's full-scale invasion, such as sanctions, military

and economic support for Ukraine, and welcoming Ukrainian refugees. Finally, some leaders, especially Draghi, devoted attention to the wider repercussions of the war, for instance its impact on the global economy and food shortages.

## Energy

Energy was the second topic to which the speakers devoted most attention. Three sub-topics can be distinguished. The first concerned the hike in energy prices and was addressed mainly by the EU leaders who spoke in 2022, when the problem was the most acute. Some speakers called for action to address this issue. For instance, Mitsotakis stated that the EU 'must have a courage to intervene in the markets when they have, essentially, ceased to function'. The second topic addressed the cause of Europe's energy problem, namely overdependence on external supplies, from Russia in particular. Here, leaders called for rapid diversification, by seeking alternative sources or building interconnectors between Member States. Christodoulides underlined that the gas reserves in Cyprus could play a role in the diversification process. The latter was mentioned also in the context of the third sub-topic, renewable energy sources. EU leaders argued that this development would not only help overcome the dependence problem, but also help in the green transition process.

## Enlargement

Enlargement was discussed by almost all the speakers. They referred to three main aspects. First, leaders expressed support for welcoming new states to the EU, listing those that are on the path to accession. This list included first and foremost Ukraine (as Marin stated, 'Ukraine's place is in the European Union'), but also Moldova and Georgia, and the Western Balkan states. The latter were mentioned more specifically by leaders from the neighbouring states, with Plenković and Golob referring specifically to Bosnia and Herzegovina. On the candidate states, Scholz insisted that the EU should keep its promises. Secondly, leaders underlined the benefits of the enlargement process, both for the new Member States – as Nauseda noted, accession is the driver for internal reforms – and for the EU as a whole. As Iohannis underlined, enlargement makes the EU stronger. Thirdly, Bettel, Denkov and Scholz stressed that enlargement offered an opportunity to open a discussion on EU reform, so as to ensure a more efficiently enlarged Union.

## EU reforms

The 'This is Europe' debates were particularly relevant in the context of the results of the Conference on the Future of Europe (CoFoE). Although the CoFoE as such was addressed directly only by Draghi, Marin, Martin and Plenković, i.e. all speakers who spoke in 2022 when the CoFoE finalised its work, others also talked about EU reforms. Scholz, for example, welcomed 'the fact that the European Parliament is working on proposals for institutional reforms', and suggested using 'the upcoming debate on reforms of the European Union to strengthen the European Commission, to always initiate infringement proceedings if our core values are violated'. While some welcomed Treaty change, others such as Marin and Martin stressed that priority should be given to reforms that can be done within the existing framework. Those speaking on EU reforms often mentioned the need for more efficient EU decision-making, and for a move from unanimity to qualified majority voting.

## The European Council

Most EU leaders referred to the work of the European Council. Christodoulides even stated that he was giving his speech in Parliament 'in the capacity of Head of State and as member of the European Council'. Speakers reported on important European Council discussions (on energy or migration for instance) and decisions (e.g. enlargement). They referred to the messages they had been giving and were planning to give to European Council colleagues. Scholz, for example, stressed that he would 'continue to promote the issue of EU reforms at the European Council'. On a more critical note, Golob conceded regarding 'hate speech' that it was the European Council that was blocking progress.

# Comparisons

## Comparing types of participant

### What can be said about the participants in the 'This is Europe' debates?

The analysis shows that, overall, a good mix of Member States participated in the 'This is Europe' debates: 50 % of the founding Member States (Germany, Italy and Luxembourg) took part, as well as countries from the 1970-2000 enlargement waves (e.g. Ireland, Greece and Finland) and Member States that have joined in the past 20 years (e.g. Croatia, Lithuania and Romania).

Some of the participating EU leaders had been members of the European Council for a long time (e.g. Bettel, Iohannis and Plenković), while others had only recently become Head of State or Government in their country (e.g. Christodoulides, Denkov and Orpo).

Although leaders from Member States of all sizes took part in the process, there was a slight under-representation of larger Member States. It should be mentioned that in the 2022-2024 period, there were national elections and/or processes to form new governments in Spain, France and Poland, circumstances that might have made interventions in the European Parliament by the leaders of these countries difficult both politically and in terms of timing.[5]

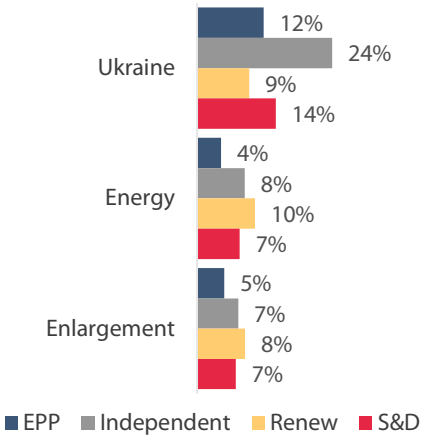
When looking at attendance based on party political affiliation, it can be observed that, of the 13 EU leaders under consideration, 5 are affiliated to the European People's Party (EPP)[6], 3 to Renew or the Alliance of Liberals and Democrats for Europe (ALDE), 2 to the Progressive Alliance of Socialists and Democrats (S&D) or the Party of European Socialists (PES); and 3 are independent Heads of State or Government. No European Council members affiliated to the European Conservatives and Reformists (ECR) addressed Parliament. When measuring attendance as a percentage of the potential participants who could have attended for each political family, ALDE/Renew had proportionately the highest attendance rate, followed by the EPP, with the S&D/PES proportionately sending the lowest number of European Council members (apart from the ECR).

EPP-affiliated EU leaders spoke the most on national policies and issues, Ukraine and EU membership. The main topics for independent leaders were Ukraine, national history and European history, whereas Renew/ALDE-affiliated speakers focused on energy, fundamental rights and Ukraine. For leaders from S&D/PES, it was Ukraine, the EU in the world and EU reforms.

Figure 8 – Member States whose leaders participated in the 'This is Europe' debate

Source: EPRS.

Figure 9 – Focus on specific topics by political group

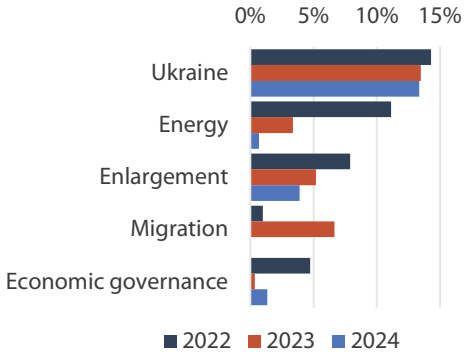



Source: EPRS.

Figure 8 shows that independent EU leaders spent almost a quarter of their time speaking about Ukraine, twice as much as leaders from any other political family. There are some other differences: the Renew/ALDE-affiliated leaders focused the most on energy and enlargement, whereas speakers from S&D/PES dedicated relatively more attention to economic governance than other political families.

There is also an important link between the moment in time when the speech was made and the attention paid to given topics. Figure 9 shows that leaders who spoke in 2022 paid significant attention to energy in the context of increasing energy prices following Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine. As the problem of high energy prices became less acute from 2023, leaders focused on it less. Migration saw a strong concentration of attention in 2023, reflecting the strong increase in irregular entries into the EU from mid-2022. The little attention paid to migration in 2024 can be explained by the fact that the speakers this year (Orpo and Iohannis) come from Member States less severely affected by migration than others. The analysis also confirms that Ukraine was the predominant topic, not only directly after the outbreak of the war, but throughout the period.

Figure 10 – Share of the topics per year of speech



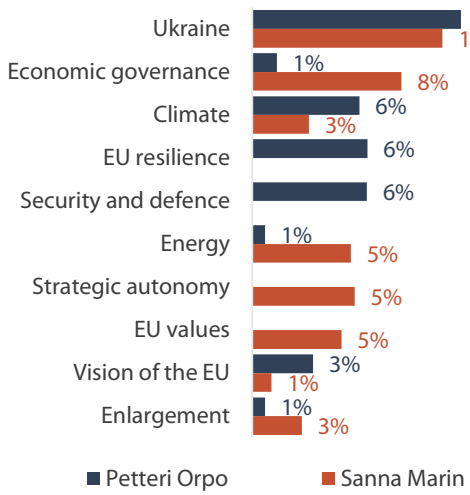

Source: EPRS.

## Comparing leaders from the same country: Case study Finland

Finland was the only Member State to have two prime ministers participate in the 'This is Europe debates': Sanna Marin, in September 2022, and Petteri Orpo in March 2024. Finland therefore offers a unique opportunity to compare views on the future of Europe as outlined by two prime ministers from the same country, but from different political families (Marin – S&D; Orpo – EPP). Obviously, they addressed the European Parliament at different times. Regarding the main topics addressed, Marin focused on Ukraine, economic governance, strategic autonomy, energy and EU values. Orpo's priorities were Ukraine, EU resilience, security and defence policy, climate, and Schengen and border protection. Ukraine was the main focus for both speakers. Both leaders underlined their support for the Ukrainians' struggle against Russian aggression and stressed the need for further EU action to support Ukraine at various levels. Orpo pointed out that any pessimism needed to be fought back, as 'every euro spent on Ukraine is a low price compared to alternative costs if Russia wins'. Marin used similar arguments, stating that 'we may count the cost of war in euros, but Ukrainians count it in human lives'.

There were no conflicting views between the two Finnish speakers on the other topics they both raised. For instance, they both agreed that the EU should diversify its supplies and acknowledged the importance of the green transition. The main differences stemmed from their reference to topics considered significant at the time of their speeches. This was the case of rising energy prices ahead of the 2022-2023 winter, which was mentioned by Marin. As this issue became less problematic in 2024, Orpo

Figure 11 – Time devoted to different topics by Marin and Orpo




Source: EPRS.

focused on diversification of energy supplies instead. Topics where the degree of attention varied between the two leaders were economic governance, EU values and enlargement, which were all addressed more by Marin than by Orpo. Conversely, Orpo spoke more about his vision for the EU, EU resilience, and security and defence policy than Marin, who placed these issues in the context of strategic autonomy, these topics very much overlapping. To conclude, although each leader highlighted different aspects, the general comparison shows more similarities than differences.

## Comparison with the 2018-2019 'Future of Europe' debates

Ahead of the 2019 European elections, the European Parliament carried out a similar initiative, the 'future of Europe' debates, which saw EU leaders speak in the Parliament's plenary sessions about their views on the future of Europe. An EPRS analysis of the future of Europe debates pinpointed similarities and differences in EU leaders' views at the time. A comparison between the 'This is Europe' debates and the earlier 'Future of Europe' debates reveals several interesting findings.

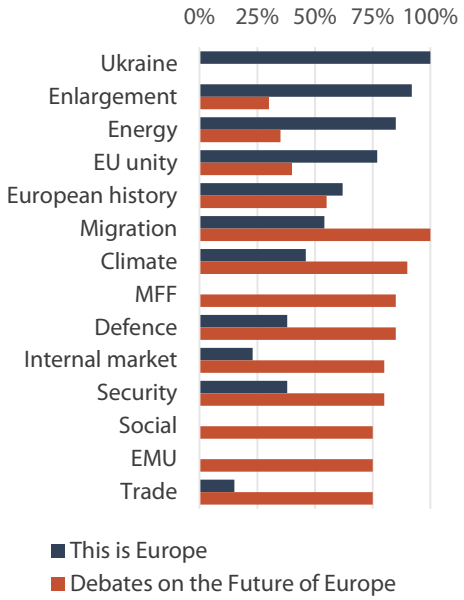
### Participation

The analysis shows that there was a substantial overlap in the countries participating in the two series of speeches. Of the 12 countries that participated in the 'This is Europe' debates, 9 Member States (Germany, Ireland, Greece, Croatia, Italy, Cyprus, Luxembourg, Romania, and Finland) also took part in the 'Future of Europe debates. For three of them, it was even the same leader (Bettel, Iohannis and Plenković). Conversely, for Bulgaria, Slovenia and Lithuania, the 'This is Europe' debate was the first time that their Head of State or Government had taken part in such an initiative in the European Parliament. The leaders of Belgium, Denmark, Estonia, Spain, France, Latvia, the Netherlands, Poland, Portugal, Slovakia and Sweden only came to the debates ahead of the 2019 European elections. Some countries - Czechia, Hungary, Malta and Austria, took part in neither initiative. It should also be noted that during the period of the 'This is Europe' debates, the following countries have held the rotating Presidency of the Council of the EU: in order, France, Czechia, Sweden, Spain and Belgium. As their leaders addressed the European Parliament to present their presidency programme to MEPs, they may not have seen the need to come again for the 'This is Europe' debates.

### Main topics

When examining the main topics addressed as part of the 'This is Europe' debates and the previous 'Future of Europe' debates, the change of context is reflected in the substance of speeches of EU leaders, as shown in Figure 12. The topics that most speakers raised during the 'This is Europe' debates (Ukraine, energy and enlargement) differ significantly from those mentioned by the majority of participants in the 'Future of Europe' debates (migration, climate and the multiannual financial framework). Other topics mentioned relatively frequently during the 'Future of Europe' debates, but not, or very little, as part of the 'This is Europe' debates were social policy, European monetary union (EMU), internal market and trade.[7] A topic where there was nearly equal attention paid was EU history.

Figure 12 – Topics raised during the 'This is Europe' and the 'Future of Europe' debates




Source: EPRS.

# Key words and memorable quotes

It is not only the number of words used for each topic that matters, but also the choice of key words that give messages a meaning. This last section looks at the different key words used in the speeches and provides an overview of selected memorable quotes.

## Building blocks for the future of Europe

The 'This is Europe' debates offered an opportunity not only to highlight the main priorities for the future of Europe, but also to share some innovative thoughts. Table 1 presents the speakers' key thoughts in the form of memorable quotes, with one selected for each leader.

Table1 – Building blocks for the future of Europe

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Do not ask what the EU can do for your country, ask what your country can do for the EU.<br>*Denkov* | The creation of the European Union is the most important collective achievement in our continent since the Enlightenment era.<br>*Christodoulides* | It is precisely the promotion and struggle for majorities and alliances that characterises us as Democrats, the search for compromises that also live up to the interests of the minority.<br>*Scholz* | Good governance is not just about responding to the crises of the moment. It is moving immediately to anticipate those to come.<br>*Draghi* |
| The fundamental rights of citizens must remain the backbone of this European Union. We cannot procrastinate on this point.<br>*Bettel* | What have we learned? First, that in an interconnected world no state can handle crises of this magnitude alone, no matter how big the state is.<br>*Mitsotakis* | 'Modern take on sovereignism' means that we are achieving our national goals by pooling and sharing our sovereignty with our friends and partners in the European Union.<br>*Plenković* | It is when that community is united and determined that that community can push the boundaries of what is possible.<br>*Golob* |
| It is the task of many generations of Europeans, not just a single one, to contribute to shaping the future of Europe. We all can and must work for more freedom, security and progress.<br>*Nauseda* | The European project requires, day by day, attention, effort, patience and honesty, if we want to live freely in a united and prosperous Europe.<br>*Iohannis* | The integration of the Union will not stop but will change constantly. We must become better, bolder and even more capable. The efficient functioning of the European Union is ultimately a question of political will.<br>*Marin* | In our union we are better together, we are stronger together, we achieve most and best when we work together<br>*Martin*<br><br>We now find ourselves at a key moment in history, one that calls for our courage, unity, and determination.<br>*Orpo* |

## Keywords

Repetition helps the audience remember and recognise important messages. With this in mind, the word cloud shows the key words that were used most frequently by the speakers. Ukraine-related words occupy the highest places in both the word cloud and the share of topics, as highlighted earlier. The same holds for energy. Enlargement provides an opposite case. Even though it was one of the most referenced topics, the word 'enlargement' was invoked only 22 times (compared to 140 for Ukraine and 120 for energy). In turn, the word 'security' was used relatively often, as the leaders used it in a variety of contexts, relating to not only security and defence policy, but also to energy, food and border security.

Figure 13 – Word cloud of key words used in the speeches

Source: EPRS.

## ENDNOTES

1 Whether a Member State is represented in the European Council by its Head of State or its Head of Government is decided at national level, with some countries holding protracted discussions on this in the past. See EPRS current membership of the European Council.

2 Kaja Kallas's speech took place before the Conference of Presidents endorsed the initiative, and the theme of the debate was narrower, focusing on the EU's role in a changing world following Russia's invasion of Ukraine. Her intervention has not therefore been included in the data analysis conducted for this briefing.

3 The data analysis is context-based. If a term such as 'EU values' is used, but in the context of Ukraine for instance, this part of the speech was coded as the latter. That is important for certain policies, such as security and defence, as some leaders spoke about these matters in the context of strategic autonomy.

4 The percentage is calculated on the basis of the time devoted to the macro-category 'policies'.

5 A number of other EU leaders had expressed their wish to come, but were unable to follow through on their commitment owing to unforeseen national developments.

6 Under the Romanian constitution, the country's president should not be a member of any political party. However, Klaus Iohannis, previously a member of an EPP-affiliated party, still regularly attends EPP pre-European Council meetings.

7 The difference concerning defence might be misleading. In the 2022-2024 period EU leaders also talked about defence policy, but they did this in the wider context of strategic autonomy.

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